Michael Maier — Atalanta Fugiens (1617)

The Boneyard is a collection of works left unfinished, unpublished, or unread at their authors' deaths — dry bones in the valley, in Ezekiel's image. Each presentation tells the scholar's story, weighs what survives of his work, and states plainly what completing it would take, so that a book the world never received whole can be met at last. Each of them was one of one. There will never be another like him, and his light will not shine again except through the work he left behind.

A Boneyard dossier — researched and presented by Robert Tilford, Hays, Kansas. Filed 14 October 2026.

Disclosure: prepared with AI assistance — the six subject reviewers named in the index are AI agents, each desk-checked at this desk; all rulings and final decisions are the author's own.

Dedication

To Michael Maier, physician and alchemist at the Prague court of Rudolf II, who made a book that asks to be used by more than one sense at once. His *Atalanta Fugiens* joins picture, verse, music, and prose in fifty emblems, and its title page says what he intended: the work is to be seen, read, meditated on, and sung. The engravings have been reprinted again and again, and the music can be reproduced, but the prose discourses that explain the emblems are the part English print left behind. This presentation is dedicated to Maier's whole design, and to restoring the part of it that a reader needs if the emblems are to be understood rather than merely admired.

The author's own terms

An emblem, in Maier's making, is not a picture alone. Each one is complete in four parts together: a motto, an engraving, an epigram set as a three-voice musical fugue, and a prose discourse that expounds the emblem at length.

The story

Michael Maier (1568–1622) was a physician and alchemist at the Prague court of Rudolf II. In 1617 his *Atalanta Fugiens* appeared at Oppenheim, from the de Bry publishing house — it is often dated 1617/1618 — and it is one of the most

richly made books of its century. It is an alchemical emblem book, which means it teaches through symbolic pictures. There are 50 emblems, and each one is complete in four parts: a motto, an engraving by Matthäus Merian, an epigram set as a three-voice musical fugue, and a prose discourse that expounds the emblem at length. It was designed, as its title page says, to be seen, read, meditated on, and sung — an early work of multimedia, made by design and not by accident.

A book built that way does not travel easily. Pictures can be reprinted. Music can be reproduced. But the discourses — the prose heart of each emblem — are what a reader needs if the emblems are to be understood rather than merely admired, and in printed English the discourses are exactly what has been missing. A reviewer's check for this collection then widened the picture in a way that changes the honest shape of the work: a complete seventeenth-century English translation of the book survives in manuscript, twice over. So the task here is not a fresh translation, and not a claim to be "first in English" in any unqualified form. It is the recovery of a translation that already exists, in handwriting.

The work and what survives

The Latin first edition is in the public domain and scanned, with copies in major collections and facsimiles in circulation; the scan identifier is to be pinned at build time. The work is in the public domain: a 1617 imprint, and the author died in 1622.

The manuscript translation survives in two copies: British Library MS Sloane 3645, and Yale's Beinecke Library, Mellon MS 48, the latter completely digitised. In addition, *Furnace and Fugue* (University of Virginia Press, 2020, edited by Nummedal and Bilak, open access) already presents "a fully searchable English translation sourced from a seventeenth-century manuscript housed in the Beinecke."

One point remains open and is recorded here as open: the copy-text year is **UNCHECKED**. The work is dated 1617 in the title of this research and 1617/1618 in its body, and no file fixes the copy-text year.

Its English fortunes

For printed scholarly editions, the pattern has been partial. H. M. E. de Jong's *Michael Maier's Atalanta Fugiens: Sources of an Alchemical Book of Emblems* (Brill,

1969; Nicolas-Hays reprints 2002 and 2014) translates the mottoes and epigrams of the 50 emblems, but gives the discourses only in summary. Partial transcriptions of the manuscript translation have been posted by volunteers — Holden, Tilton, and Branwin, via the Alchemy website — and a new translation of the discourses has been reported in progress by Peter Branwin. In progress is not published.

The bounded finding of this research, verified on 14 October 2026 and then refined by the reviewer's check, is this: **No complete published English translation of the whole work — mottoes, epigrams, and discourses together — found after research.**

What completing it would take

Completing the work, on the refined framing, is an editorial rescue rather than a new translation: transcribe and collate the surviving manuscript English translation against the 1618 Latin and German, lightly modernise it, and issue it as a printed book with the public-domain 1618 engravings, in instalments of ten emblems. The fugues' notation is reproduced from the original as image matter. The review standard set for it is a Latinist of the emblem tradition.

That shape is less grand than a fresh translation, and it is the true one. Maier made a book to be seen, read, meditated on, and sung. An edition that gives English readers the discourses at last, from the English words a seventeenth-century translator already found for them, restores the part of his design that print left behind.

Sources

- https://www.weiserantiquarian.com/pages/books/69560 (de Jong edition: mottoes/epigrams translated, expositions summarized)
- https://www.yumpu.com/en/document/view/16773756/maier-atalanta-fugienspdf/3 (Adam McLean's note: the Sloane 3645 and Mellon MS 48 manuscript translations; the volunteer transcription project; the discourses' translation outstanding)
- https://En-Academic.com/dic.nsf/enwiki/637471 (Maier bibliography: Atalanta Fugiens, Oppenheim 1617)
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